



Name: _____

Grade & Section: _____

ACTIVITY SHEET #5: Writing a Critique



GEAR UP

MELC: Use appropriate critical writing critique such as formalism, feminism, etc.

After the learners have finished answering this activity sheet, they will be able to:

1. define a critique and analyze its features;
2. identify different approaches in writing a critiques such as formalism, feminism, etc.; and
3. write an objective/balanced review or critique of a work of art, an event, or a program.



ENGAGE

WHAT IS A CRITIQUE?

Critique is derived from ancient Greek (“kritike”). It is defined as a careful judgment in which you shape your opinion about the strengths and weaknesses of a piece of writing or work of art. It is not a summary of the piece, rather, it is the critical evaluation to further understand validity, worth, effect, use of the material that interests readers, and/or the recommendation or appeal for further appreciation.

CRITICAL APPROACHES IN WRITING A CRITIQUE

1. FORMALISM OR NEW CRITICISM

This approach claims that all that are important in analyzing and understanding the text can be found in the piece of writing or text itself. Outside information regarding the author, society of the time, politics or any other external context are no longer needed. The text is independent. It has a fixed meaning. It is timeless and universal. It requires a close and intent reading of the text concentrating on the relationships within the text that showcases its distinct characteristics or form. The following are guide questions for this approach.

- What is the title, setting, other elements etc. and to what extent it is symbolic?
- What kind of language does the author use?
- How does the writer's diction reveal or reflect the work's meaning?
- How do various elements of the work reinforce its meaning?
- What recurring patterns (repeated or related words, images, etc.) can you find? What is the effect of these patterns or motifs?
- What tone and mood are created at various parts of the work?
- What is the effect of the plot, and what parts specifically produce that effect?
- What figures of speech are used? (metaphors, similes, etc.)
- How does the author create tone and mood? What relationship is there between tone and mood and the effect of the story?
- How do the various elements interact to create a unified whole? How is the work's structure unified?

2. FEMINISM

This approach emphasizes the importance or relevance of women as subjects and how gender been perceived in the piece. The images of women and the underlying concepts of femininity including economic, societal, psychological, and archetypal nature of women are examined. This approach likewise stresses equality for a male dominated society.

The following guide questions using the feminism:

- How are women's lives portrayed in the work?
- Is the form and content of the work influenced by the writer's gender?
- How do male and female characters relate to one another? Are these relationships sources of conflict? Are these conflicts resolved?
- Does the work challenge or affirm traditional views of women?
- How do the images of women in the story reflect patriarchal social forces that have impeded women's efforts to achieve full equality with men?
- What marital expectations are imposed on the characters? What effect do these expectations have?
- What behavioral expectations are imposed on the characters? What effect do these expectations have?
- How does the marital status of a character affect her decisions or happiness?
- How does culture view women vs. men? How is the relationship between men and women portrayed?
- What are the power relationships between men and women (or characters assuming male/female roles)?



3. READER RESPONSE

This approach stresses the attachment or strong connectionism of an individual reader's mind to the piece at hand. The reader herself can put meaning and interpret every part of the text. The text is nothing unless it has been read and interpreted by the reader. The reader's reaction and interaction made out of the piece recreates and develops a further depth of meaning. The manner a poem or a short story is read or delivered strengthens and invokes visuals and imagination to a much sought individual appreciation.

- Who is the reader? Who is the implied reader?
- What experiences, thoughts, or knowledge does the text evoke?
- What aspects or characters of the text do you identify or disidentify with, and how does this process of identification affect your response to the text?
- What is the difference between your general reaction to (e.g., like or dislike) and reader-oriented interpretation of the text?
- How does the interaction of text and reader create meaning?
- What does the text have to do with you, personally, and with your life (past, present or future)?
- How much does the text agree or clash with your view of the world, and what you consider right and wrong?
- What did you learn, and how much were your views and opinions challenged or changed by this text, if at all? Did the text communicate with you? Why or why not?
- What can you praise about the text? What problems did you have with it?

4. MARXIST CRITICISM

This approach tries to unfold how socioeconomic status affects hierarchy or conflicts involving social classes in the masterpiece. This approach likewise attempts to answer the following questions:

- What are the differences between economic classes? What conflict has arisen between the working class and the elite?
- What implication may the socioeconomic system bring?
- What social class has been emphasized and how was this portrayed in the piece?
- What kinds of power (social, economic, sexual, physical, etc.) are evident in the text? What is the social order? What role does class play in the work; what is the author's analysis of class relations?
- Who has power in the text? How do they maintain and/or gain power?
- How do characters overcome oppression? What does the work say about oppression; or are social conflicts ignored or blamed elsewhere?
- What ideologies (values, beliefs, social roles) are evident in the text? Do characters recognize the oppressive social order/ideologies?

OTHER APPROACHES

5. BIOGRAPHICAL APPROACH: Focuses on connection of work to author's personal experiences. Understanding authors' life can help in comprehending the work. This aspect amplifies meaning and relevance of the text.

- What aspects of the author's personal life are relevant to this story?
- Which of the author's stated beliefs are reflected in the work?
- Does the writer challenge or support the values of her contemporaries?
- What seem to be the author's major concerns? Do they reflect any of the writer's personal experiences?
- Do any of the events in the story correspond to events experienced by the author?
- Do any of the characters in the story correspond to real people?

6. HISTORICAL APPROACH: This approach focuses on connection of work to the historical period in which it was written; literary historians attempt to connect the historical background of the work to specific aspects of the work.

- How does it reflect the time in which it was written? How accurately does the story depict the time in which it is set?
- What literary or historical influences helped to shape the form and content of the work?
- How does the story reflect the attitudes and beliefs of the time in which it was written or set? (Consider beliefs and attitudes related to race, religion, politics, gender, society, philosophy, etc.)
- What historical events or movements might have influenced this writer?
- Does the story reveal or contradict the prevailing values of the time in which it was written? Does it provide an opposing view of the period's prevailing values?
- How important is it the historical context (the work's and the reader's) to interpreting the work?

7. PSYCHOLOGICAL APPROACH: This approach focuses on the psychology of characters.

- What forces are motivating the characters?
- Which behaviors of the characters are conscious ones? Which are unconscious?
- What conscious or unconscious conflicts exist between the characters?
- Given their backgrounds, how plausible is the characters' behavior?



8. SOCIOLOGICAL APPROACH: This approach focuses on man's relationship to others in society, politics, religion, and business.

- What is the relationship between the characters and their society?
- Does the story address societal issues, such as race, gender, and class?
- How do social forces shape the power relationships between groups or classes of people in the story?
- Who has the power, and who doesn't? Why?
- How does the story reflect urban, rural, or suburban values?
- How do economic conditions determine the direction of the characters' lives?
- Does the work challenge or affirm the social order it depicts?

9. ARCHETYPAL APPROACH: This approach focuses on connections to other literature, mythological/biblical allusions, archetypal images, symbols, characters, and themes.

- How does this story resemble other stories in plot, character, setting, or symbolism?
- What universal experiences are depicted? Are patterns suggested?
- Are seasons used to suggest a pattern or cycle?
- Does the protagonist undergo any kind of transformation, such as movement from innocence to experience, that seems archetypal? Are the names significant?
- Is there a Christ-like figure in the work? Does the writer allude to biblical or mythological literature? For what purpose?
- How does the work reflect the hopes, fears, and expectations of entire cultures (for example, the ancient Greeks)?
- How do myths attempt to explain the unexplainable: origin of man? Purpose and destiny of human beings?
- How do stories from one culture correspond to those of another? (For example, creation myths, flood myths, etc.)
- How does the story reflect the experiences of death and rebirth?
- What archetypal events occur in the story? (Quest? Initiation? Scapegoating? Descents into the underworld? Ascents into heaven?) What archetypal images occur? (Water, rising sun, setting sun, symbolic colors)

10. PHILOSOPHICAL APPROACH: This approach focuses on themes, view of the world, moral statements, author's philosophy, etc.

- What view of life does the story present? Which character best articulates this viewpoint? 2. According to this work's view of life, what is mankind's relationship to God? To the universe?
- What moral statement, if any, does this story make? Is it explicit or implicit?
- What is the author's attitude toward his world? Toward fate? Toward God?
- What is the author's conception of good and evil?
- What does the work say about the nature of good or evil?
- What does the work say about human nature?

WRITING STRUCTURE

A. Introduction (Short paragraph/paragraph/s - one to three sentences or more)

This must include the title of the material, the author, and your assessment of the material. For a short story, this part may also include the background of the piece, your opinion, and the thesis. The thesis includes the subject, your opinion and your main point.

B. Plot Summary/Description (Short paragraph/s - one to three sentences or more)

This involves the gist or the description of the material. For a short story, this is the understanding of plot or summary of the piece examined.

C. Analysis and Interpretation/ Evaluation (One to three or more paragraph/s)

In this phase you will retrieve the guiding questions of your choice to include in your outlined discussion. It does not necessarily mean that you will include all in one but rather only those you think are needed depending on the arguments or points you wanted to stress.

Likewise, though critical approaches are not exclusive and may be used at the same time, it is better to focus and use at least one among the many approaches.

For the formalist view for example, any among the character, dialogue, setting, conflict, suspense, ending and plot would speak by itself. Analysis of the poem for formalists may involve imagery, sound, figurative language, language and other elements.

D. Conclusion/Closing paragraph (One to three paragraphs)

At this point, you shall be able to link your thoughts reinforced with your assessment in the introduction. If in any case it is possible for you to compare the masterpiece to a similar work, the better. Your recommendation depends on how you have perceived the material observing all fair judgment and appreciation.

Note: The length and the depth of your critique depends on the task required to you. Two to three paragraphs could even be possible to include all the parts cited above.



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TEST

Directions: *Using the hinted questions below, write the critical approach used to a certain content or piece of writing on the blank. Choose your answer from the box below.*

Feminism	Reader Response	Biographical	Archetypal
Formalism	Marxist	Historical	Psychological

- _____ 1. What is the theme of the poem?
- _____ 2. What are women's roles that are apparent or observable in the piece?
- _____ 3. How does time transitions before affects the perceived culture of today?
- _____ 4. To what extent the main character's actuations are molded by author's experiences herself?
- _____ 5. What do you feel the moment you have read lines 1, 2, and 3?



REINFORCE

Directions: *Read the following examples of a critique and determine the approach used. Write your answers on the blank.*

- _____ 1. The title of the work already gives an idea as to what it means. In the story, this metaphor is used to refer to Alfredo's love for Julia, a woman he meets and falls for one fateful summer. Not only is the title an indicator of what is to come, even the fate of the characters in the story can already be seen through their names.
- _____ 2. The story is a study of power imbalance brought about by gender. In the beginning, Dead Stars already clearly illustrates the gender roles ingrained in Filipino Society: Don Julian and the judge are portrayed as the male leaders of the household, taking up lofty professions such as business and law while the women are portrayed accomplishing domestic tasks such as tending the children and preparing food.
- _____ 3. Despite being limited in length, Dead Stars manages to evoke various feelings which ultimately build up the ending. While Alfredo is the center of the story, as a woman reader it is hard not to feel greatly for Esperanza. Esperanza can only be seen through the perspective of Alfredo. This does a disservice to her, as we can only know her through the description of someone 9 who does not love her anymore. Still, it is also through Alfredo's descriptions and his unfaithfulness that Esperanza gains sympathy from the reader.
- _____ 4. The imbalanced societal power play is evident in the short story in the form of the treatment of the characters based on their class. This is most easily evident in the conversation between Alfredo and his fiancée. Esperanza, about Calixta, their note-carrier who grew up in the latter's family. The scene depicts a parallelism in the circumstance of Alfredo and his new love, Julia, and Calixta and her live-in partner.
- _____ 5. "Dead Stars" is the 1925 short story that gave birth to modern Philippine writing in English. Paz Marquez-Benitez, in her masterpiece Dead Stars, did not only write about a love story. Most importantly, her writing reflects the time in which the literary work was written along with the language, the norms and the way people think. It serves as a literary time machine for readers as it enables them to understand how courtship, marriage and fidelity were viewed through the early 1900 standards. It renders a sound comparison between the past and the present, the existing modern culture and the fading, almost obsolete tradition.



INTEGRATE

Direction: Read the literary piece below. Then, answer the questions that follow.

Why the Dead Come Back No More

An Ifugao Myth

A very long time ago, there lived a very kind woman with her three little children. She loved her children so much that she worked hard to be able to feed them.

One day she fell ill, and in a short time she died. Her spirit went to Kadungayan, of course, as she lived a good life, but one night she thought of her poor little children whom she left on earth. She imagined that no one cared for them and that they must be hungry and cold. She pitied them so much that she decided to go back to earth.

When she reached their house, she called her eldest child to open the door for her. The children recognized their mother's voice and opened the door at once. She went in and spoke to them, but they could not see her because it was so very dark and their fire had gone out. The children had not built a fire since their mother died. The children were too small, and they did not know how to build one.

So the woman sent her eldest child to beg for fire from the neighbors as she felt very cold. The poor child went to the first house, but when she told them that she wanted fire for her mother who had come back home, the people just laughed at her. They did not give her fire. She went to the next house, but the same thing happened. Thus, she went to the next house, from house to house, but no one believed that her mother had come back. They thought the poor child had gone out of her mind. So the poor child went home without fire. The woman was very angry with all the unkind people. She said, "Am I to die a second death because men are so selfish? Come, my children, let us all go to that better place where I came from – Kadungayan. There are no selfish people there."

She took a jar of water and went outside in the yard. She shouted to all the people, "Ah, what selfish people you all are. From this time on all people will follow my example. No man will ever come back again to earth after death." With these words she smashed the jar on a big stone. This made a horrible sound. All the people became silent with fear.

The next morning the people came out to see what had caused the great voice. They saw the bits of broken jar and they found the three children dead. They now knew that the woman had really come back home that night and that in her anger at their selfishness had taken her three children with her. The people were so sorry for not having given fire to the little girl.

Since then, no dead person has ever come back to earth.

Source: Tagalog Language Seaside, (28 February 2020). Why the Dead Come Back No More. Retrieved from <http://seaside2.niu.edu/philippine-folk-tales/ifugao-myths-why-the-dead-come-back-no-more/>

Questions:

1. How does the author create tone and mood? What relationship is there between tone and mood and the effect of the story?

2. How are women's lives portrayed in the work?

3. What did you feel after reading the literature? Why?

4. Which part of the text can you relate to? In what way?

5. What ideologies (values, beliefs, social roles) are evident in the text? Do characters recognize the oppressive social order/ideologies?



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ASSESS

Directions: Write *T* if the statement is true and *F* if it is false.

- _____ 1. A critique paper involves higher order thinking skills.
- _____ 2. A critique generally use the same organization of ideas.
- _____ 3. A critique must always be organized using a structure.
- _____ 4. Feminist criticism relates to conflicts between classes.
- _____ 5. Marxist criticism involves the analysis of the intrinsic features of a text.
- _____ 6. More than half of a critique paper should be devoted to the summary.
- _____ 7. The name of the author and the title of the reviewed article are placed at the end of the critique.
- _____ 8. The reviewer's overall impression of the material being reviewed should be placed in the introduction.
- _____ 9. When writing a critique, only one perspective should be used.
- _____ 10. Writing a critique is exclusively for scholars.



SHARPEN

Directions: Choose one approach to writing a critique discussed in this activity sheet. Following the structure of a critique, write a critical analysis of the literary piece you read in *Integrate*. If the space is not enough, you may use another sheet of paper.

RUBRIC

Criteria	Standard	Points	Score
Introduction	Short paragraph/paragraph/s - one to three sentences or more Introduction Statement (include Title, author, your opinion) Your thesis (the point you are trying to make)	5	
Plot Summary/Description	Short paragraph/s – one to three sentences or more This involves the gist or the description of the material. For a short story, this is the understanding of plot or summary of the piece examined	5	
Analysis and Interpretation/Evaluation	Your Critique - this should clearly show the approach you chose. It should answer the guide questions. Critique are well-explained.	10	
Conclusion/Closing paragraph	Link your thoughts reinforced with your assessment in the introduction	5	

References:

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